

400 YEARS OF WOMEN'S SHOES

From the towering chopines of 16th- and 17th-century Europe, to 18th-century embroidered silk slippers and 1930s dazzling diamanté sandals, these diverse shoes from the past 400 years indicate much about the status of the women who wore them. It was quite usual at certain periods, such as the 18th and early 19th centuries, for women's shoes to be made of fabric rather than leather, perhaps because their wearers spent a large part of their time indoors. In the 21st century slender stiletto heels by designers such as Christian Louboutin, Manolo Blahnik, and Jimmy Choo are "must-have" accessories – possibly worn only on special occasions.



1600 Venetian chopine overshoe made from kid leather, with punched decoration, silk overlay, and pine-wood sole



1750s Mule slipper of white and gold striped and figured silk, with a kid-leather sole and shaped heel



1790–1800 Leather shoe in pink, with cream bow trim and faint striped pattern, made in England



1810 English boot made from pale yellow kid leather, with laced front fastening and yellow ribbon bow



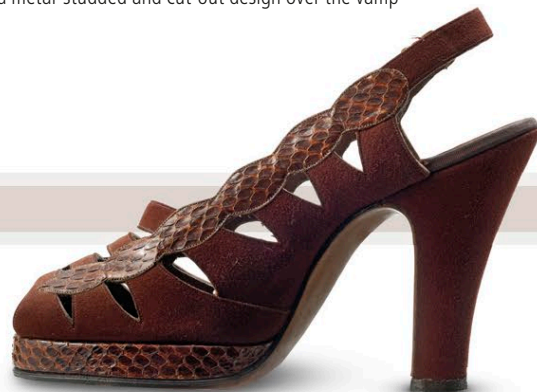
1905 Austrian dress shoe made from kid leather, with a metal-studded and cut-out design over the vamp



1918 Ribbon tie shoe in oyster glacé kid, with ribbon tie and cut-out detail, designed and made by Bally of Switzerland



1926 Walking shoe of two-tone calf leather and crocodile skin, with wooden heel and tab styled like a golf-shoe flap, made by Bally



1950s American sling-back shoe of brown suede and reptile skin, with a high heel and front platform



1960s Leather court shoe of mustard-yellow imitation leather, with pin heel, pointed toe, and cut-out sides



1970s Platform sandal made from blue corduroy with a rubber sole